Childcare Price Analysis Final

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Summary of Analysis

This project analyzed the National Database of Childcare Prices (NDCP), a county-level dataset of weekly childcare cost estimates published by the U.S. Department of Labor Women's Bureau. The dataset includes prices across four child age groups: infant, toddler, preschool, and school-age, and two provider types: center-based and family childcare. Analysis spanned 2008 through 2018, with 2018 used as the primary story year. The goal was to help working parents understand how childcare costs shift as children age, how provider type affects price, and how geography creates meaningful variation in what families pay.

Findings

Infant and toddler care consistently carry the highest weekly costs. In 2018, median center-based infant care ran $153.60 per week, compared to $106.22 for school-age children, a roughly 31% premium in the earliest years. Family childcare followed the same downward pattern but at a lower price level, falling from $120.00 for infants to $98.77 for school-age children. Center-based care exceeded family childcare at every age group, with the gap widest for infants at $33.60 per week. Geography also produced sharp differences: for center-based infant care in 2018, county prices ranged from $108 at the 10th percentile to $236 at the 90th percentile, a $128 weekly spread that frames childcare affordability as a location issue as much as a household budgeting issue. At the median county, center-based infant care accounted for roughly 16.1% of estimated weekly household income, and family infant care, about 12.5%.

Assumptions

The analysis assumes that weekly childcare prices in the NDCP represent a reasonable estimate of full-time childcare costs for working parents, and that county medians are a valid local proxy even though individual provider prices will vary. Imputed values in the dataset are treated as acceptable estimates per the technical guide. County median household income (MHI) is used only as a rough local context, not as a direct household affordability calculation. No adjustment was made for inflation when presenting the 2018 snapshot.

Items That Still Need Clarification

The dataset measures prices, not the availability of childcare slots, which limits what the story can say about access. Informal care from relatives, friends, or neighbors is not captured. Because household-level income is absent, the budget burden figures remain estimates tied to county MHI rather than actual family earnings. Additionally, years after 2018 are not included, so the story does not reflect pandemic-era disruptions or more recent price changes.

Direction of Story, Plan, and Message

The story centers on one core message: childcare costs hit hardest in the early years, and where you live shapes what you pay. The project moves from evidence to action, showing parents the price pattern by age and geography, then encouraging them to use local data when advocating for employer flexibility, dependent-care benefits, or childcare support programs. The call to action is practical and grounded in the data: bring your county's numbers to the conversations that matter.

Target Audience

The primary audience is working parents with children aged ten or younger who want clear, actionable information without technical jargon. A secondary audience includes HR professionals and local leaders who make decisions about family benefits and childcare support. All three mediums were built to serve non-technical users first.

Mediums Included and Why

Three mediums were produced. The interactive dashboard lets parents filter by state, county, year, provider type, and age group to see a price directly relevant to their situation, answering the practical question of what childcare costs in their area. The one-page infographic provides a printable summary that can be shared with an employer or brought to a community meeting without requiring any digital interaction. The short explainer presentation gives the broader story structure needed for a workplace or community talk, moving from the problem to concrete actions in eight slides. Together, the three mediums cover exploration, quick reference, and persuasive presentation.

Design Decisions

All three mediums use a restrained, blue-based palette to signal credibility and maintain visual continuity. Chart types were kept simple: bar charts for age and provider comparisons, a range display for geography, and a line chart for trends, so a general audience could read them quickly. The infographic uses a vertical banded layout for scannable sequence. The dashboard uses card-based grouping to separate filters, summary metrics, and charts. Each slide in the presentation carries a single takeaway, keeping the audience focused on the story rather than dense text. Imputation notes and data limitations were included in all three mediums to maintain transparency.

Ethical Considerations

The NDCP data was sourced from the U.S. Department of Labor Women's Bureau and is publicly available with accompanying documentation. No transformations were made that altered the underlying values; calculations were limited to medians and derived weekly estimates consistent with the technical guide's methods. Imputed values were not removed but were clearly labeled in the dashboard to avoid misleading users. Budget burden figures were framed as rough context, not precise affordability measures, to reduce the risk of misinterpretation. No data was filtered silently, the presentation notes which counties and years lacked reported values. The dataset was acquired from a federal government source, so no legal or regulatory concerns apply to its use. Informal care and slot availability were identified as explicit gaps to prevent overstating what the data shows. The primary ethical risk is that county-level medians could be read as individual household costs; this was mitigated through repeated framing notes across all three mediums.

Lessons Learned

The most useful adjustment for a future project would be building the dashboard and infographic in parallel from the start rather than sequentially, since design decisions made early in one medium ended up constraining choices in the other. Spending more time upfront on the infographic's layout logic of the infographic would have reduced iteration cycles. The aspect of the project that worked best was keeping a consistent visual language across all three mediums; the blue palette and simple chart choices held the story together even when formats changed. If starting over, more effort would go into finding a complementary income dataset to support a stronger affordability layer in the dashboard, which remained the weakest element of the analysis due to the absence of household-level data.